

Peace or Push? Understanding Global Patterns of Refugee Return

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Sept 4, 2026

Abstract

When do refugees return? A core premise of the refugee regime is that refugees remain abroad while home is unsafe and return as security improves. Yet using a novel global dataset, I show that most recorded returns occur during ongoing conflict, while many refugees remain abroad after wars end. I argue that realized return depends not only on hypothetical individual-level preferences over origin and asylum, but also on population-level constraints on whether refugees can remain abroad and whether they can afford to return. I show that exclusion policies and conflict in asylum are associated with substantially higher return, including while conflict continues at home, while UNHCR repatriation assistance, which helps finance transportation and rehabilitation, is associated with greater return. I introduce the Global Refugee Return Dataset, covering 293 origin–asylum dyads from 1980 to 2023, which documents coerced returns systematically missed by UNHCR statistics and provides new data on exclusion policies and repatriation assistance. These findings help explain why refugees may return before home is safe, yet remain displaced after peace.

*I am grateful to James D. Fearon, Jeremy Weinstein, Jens Hainmueller, Michael Allen, and Judith Goldstein for their invaluable advising and feedback. I thank Idean Salehyan, Lisa Blaydes, Claire Adida, Andrew Shaver, Perisa Davutoglu, and participants in the Online Peace Science Colloquium 2026, the Stanford-Berkeley IPE Colloquium 2026, the Berlin Meeting on the Political Economy of Development (MoPED) 2026, the Stanford IPE Workshop 2025, and the APSA Migration and Citizenship Dissertation Workshop 2026 for helpful comments. I thank Andrew Shaver for hosting this project in the Political Violence Lab, and the lab's research assistants for their help in constructing the Global Refugee Return dataset, most notably Samantha Terriquez, as well as Franklin Huang, David Hsueh, Joeb Stout, Evan Richardson, Caroline Robbins, Kianna Victor, Citlali Hernandez Pulido, Jade Gomez-Castro, Thomas Lobaton, Zex Liu, Jennifer Lara, Kev Young, Maria Fernanda Bello, Marium Fatima Agha, Ryder Stoddard, Stephanie Udeze, Toros Pinar, Abigail McMurry, Anvi Gaikwad, Ceyda Akkus, Damara Gomez, Ulysses Trejo Vasquez, Aditya Joshi, Shreya Lakshmanan, Ashley Salazar, Daniel Lvovsky, Swetha Balamurugan, Heidi King, Chiedza Manjengwa, Maren Rhee, Anastasia Ginzburg, and Sage Cerda. I also thank Georgia Sasso, Suha Choi, and Jelena Hertzler for their research assistance. Finally, I thank the UNHCR archives team for hosting me in their archives.

1 Introduction

When do refugees return? The expectation in both the international refugee regime and existing research is that refugees return once the conflict or persecution that caused their displacement has ended. The regime is designed to protect refugees in asylum for as long as they would face persecution or serious harm upon return. Its legal cornerstone is the principle of *non-refoulement*, which prohibits states from returning refugees under those conditions.¹ UNHCR treats voluntary repatriation as its preferred “durable solution.”² Studies of return intentions likewise find that refugees become more willing to return as security in their country of origin improves (e.g., Alrababah et al., 2023; Beaman, Onder and Onder, 2022; Adema et al., 2025; Al Husein and Wagner, 2023).

Global historical patterns of refugee return, however, do not align with these expectations. The novel Global Refugee Return (GRR) dataset, covering 293 origin–asylum dyads from 1980 to 2023, reveals two striking patterns. First, more than three-quarters of recorded returns occurred while conflict was ongoing in the country of origin. Second, refugees often do not return when there is peace: only 8 of 24 wars that ended and remained at peace for five years saw even half the refugee population return within that period. Refugees therefore frequently return when prevailing accounts predict that they should remain abroad, while many remain displaced when those accounts predict that they should return.

Why do refugees return during war, yet often remain in asylum after peace? To answer these questions, I argue that we have to look beyond refugees’ individual or household-level preferences over origin and asylum to the population-level conditions that determine whether those preferences can be acted upon. Most quantitative research examines return intentions within particular contexts, showing that willingness to return depends especially on security at home relative to conditions in asylum (e.g., Alrababah et al., 2023; Al Husein and Wagner, 2023; Adema et al., 2025). This helps explain where refugees would prefer to live, but not necessarily when large refugee populations actually move.

I show that realized return is concentrated around three population-level shifts that map onto constraints on refugees’ choices: whether they are able to remain in asylum and whether they have the resources required to return. First, a large share of return occurs amid asylum-side push, particularly exclusion policies designed to force refugees out and conflict in the country of asylum. Both can make staying in asylum untenable

¹The principle is codified in Article 33(1) of the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and its 1967 Protocol. It is also recognized as a rule of customary international law and therefore binds states regardless of whether they are parties to the Convention.

²The other two durable solutions are local integration and third-country resettlement. UNHCR has treated voluntary repatriation as its preferred durable solution since the mid-1980s (Barnett and Finnemore, 2004; Loescher, 2001).

even when conditions at home remain dangerous. 47.4% of recorded return occurs in years with either asylum shock, compared with 15.4% in the three years after war ends. These pressures are common because most refugees live in low- and middle-income countries, often in neighboring states where they may face new conflicts or governments that restrict their ability to remain (UNHCR, 2025).

Second, peace may fail to produce return not only because refugees prefer to remain in asylum, as existing research emphasizes, but also because those who want to return may lack the resources to do so. After years of restricted employment or camp residence, refugees may be unable to finance transportation and rebuild their lives at home. UNHCR repatriation programs can relax this constraint by providing transportation and reintegration assistance, but whether such assistance is available depends not only on conditions of displacement, but also on funding from donor countries and decisions made by international bureaucrats. Consistent with this argument, the post-war return rate is 4.4% in dyad-years without a UNHCR repatriation programme, compared with 31.3% when a programme is operating.

I evaluate this argument using within-dyad models, event studies, observable implications, and historical comparisons. Severe exclusion policies are associated with 2.97 times the return rate, while low-intensity conflict in asylum is associated with 2.24 times the rate. High UNHCR repatriation funding is associated with 1.82 times the return rate relative to no funding, and moving from low to high funding is associated with approximately 2.3 times the rate. Stacked event studies reinforce these findings. Return rises sharply following the onset of severe exclusion policies and conflict in asylum, and approximately doubles when a major repatriation programme begins, with little evidence of pre-trends in these three cases.

The evidence also supports several observable implications of the theory. Return is highly concentrated in particular dyads and years, refugees from the same origin return at different rates depending on conditions in asylum, and asylum-side push remains associated with return even while conflict continues at home. Historical cases trace these mechanisms: Rwandan refugees returned at different times across neighboring asylum countries despite facing the same conditions at home, while Eritrean refugees remained in Sudan after independence until an organized UNHCR repatriation program began.

Existing explanations nevertheless remain important. War endings are associated with 2.71 times the return rate, and refugees are less likely to return to more repressive origin countries or from wealthier asylum countries. Other origin-country conditions, including income and the broader intensity of conflict, are less consistently associated with return. Thus, improving conditions at home matter, but they cannot by themselves explain when large refugee populations actually move.

This research makes three contributions. First, despite the centrality of repatriation to

the international refugee regime, macro-level patterns of return remain understudied. Existing quantitative work has taught us a great deal about where specific refugee groups would prefer to live, but much less about when displacement actually ends. I provide the first global analysis of realized refugee return using improved historical data and bring into quantitative study two factors long discussed in historical and legal scholarship but rarely examined systematically: coercive repatriation and the role of UNHCR in facilitating return.

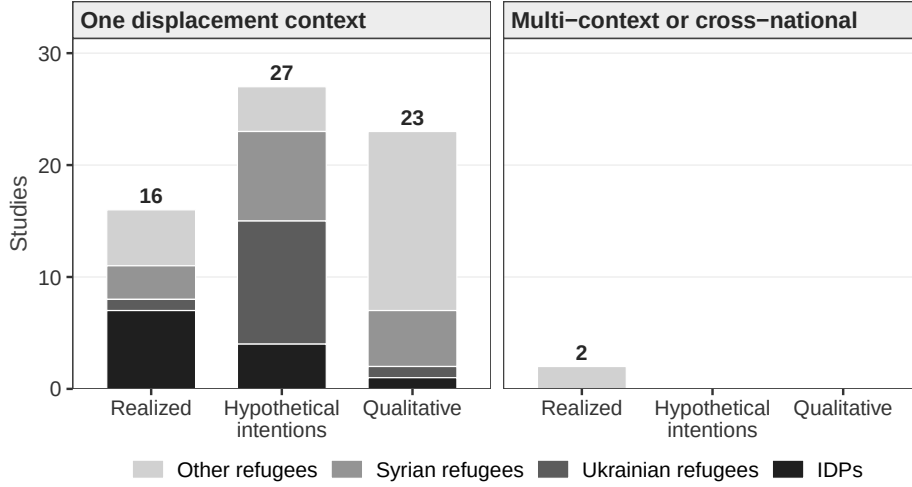
Second, the paper makes a major data contribution. The principal existing UNHCR data systematically undercount coerced returns and therefore mischaracterize when and why refugees return. With 36 research assistants, I constructed the GRR dataset by digitizing and coding 7,526 dyad-years of archival country reports compiled through field visits, interviews, and media reporting. GRR enables systematic analysis by providing both a more accurate measure of return itself and new measures of the conditions that may explain it, including exclusion policies and UNHCR repatriation financing. When I re-estimate the analysis using UNHCR data, the principal asylum-side relationships largely disappear and the results produce patterns that are difficult to reconcile with existing explanations, consistent with the systematic undercounting of forced return. GRR also records broader *de facto* asylum conditions, complementing *de jure* datasets such as the Dataset of World Refugee and Asylum Policies (DWRAP) (Blair, Grossman and Weinstein, 2022).

Third, the paper connects research on refugees and international security with IPE scholarship on international regimes. Relative to regimes governing trade, finance, the environment, and human rights, the international refugee system has received comparatively little systematic attention in quantitative IPE research.³ The data and results here enable an assessment of compliance with its core legal principle of *non-refoulement*, revealing systematic violations in some cases and continued protection in others. This variation raises a question central to research on international regimes but rarely examined systematically in the refugee context: why are core rules upheld in some cases but violated at scale in others, and when do international organizations constrain rather than accommodate those violations (Chayes and Chayes, 1993; Simmons, 2000; Mitchell, 1994; Stone, 2011)?

The article first reviews existing research and documents the prevalence of return during conflict. I then develop the argument, introduce the GRR dataset and its advantages over UNHCR data, and test the theory using within-dyad models, event studies, and additional observable implications, before tracing the proposed mechanisms through Rwandan and Eritrean cases.

³Important policy, IR, historical, and legal work on the refugee regime includes Loescher (2001), Barnett (2001a), Chimni (2000), Skran (1995), Betts (2009), Betts (2010), Abdelaaty (2021), Arar (2017), and Davutoglu (2025).

Figure 1: Literature review of empirical research on refugee return



Notes: Search: 19 journals, 2006–2026; citation tracing; 2024 World Bank–UNHCR Joint Data Center review; targeted searches. Displacement contexts may span multiple origins within one host or one origin across multiple hosts; cross-national studies span multiple contexts. See Appendix for study list.

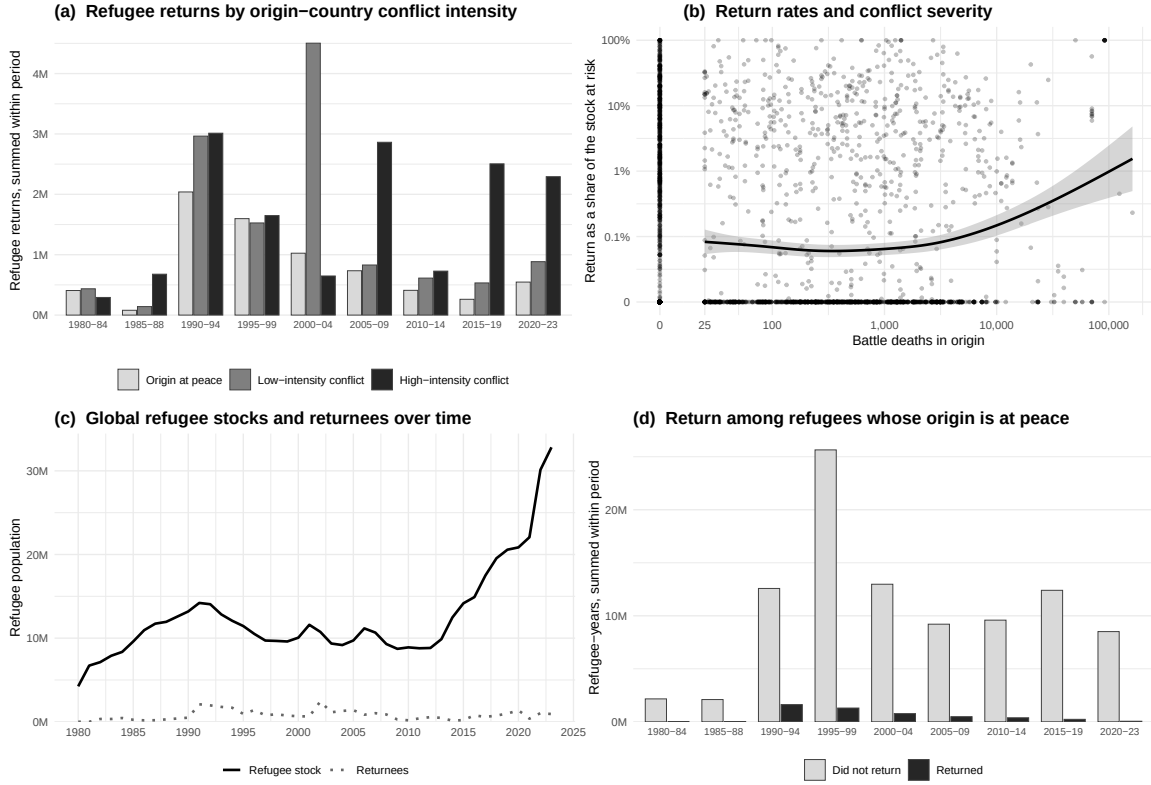
2 Puzzling Patterns of Refugee Return

Figure 1 shows that existing research on refugee return has focused primarily on stated return intentions within particular displacement contexts, especially among Syrian and Ukrainian refugees. Drawing on household models of migration choice (Borjas, 1987), this work generally asks whether refugees want to return once it is safe to do so, reflecting security concerns and attachment to their country of origin, or whether economic opportunities and living conditions in asylum make remaining abroad more attractive.

The consistent finding of this research is that origin security conditions are the primary determinant of return intentions (Alrababah et al., 2023; Beaman, Onder and Onder, 2022; Adema et al., 2025). The “threshold model” developed by Alrababah et al. (2023), for example, argues that refugees consider asylum-country economic factors only once a minimum level of safety at home has been reached: Syrian refugees in Lebanon were unlikely to consider returning while Syria remained unsafe, even when they faced poor living conditions in asylum. Political conditions and attachment to home also shape return intentions (Kaya and Orchard, 2020; Ghosn et al., 2021). By contrast, evidence on asylum-country conditions is mixed: some studies find they shape return intentions, others find little relationship, and Beaman, Onder and Onder (2022) find that better conditions in exile are associated with greater realized return (Kayaoglu, Şahin-Mencütek and Erdoğan, 2022; Müller-Funk and Fransen, 2023; Alrababah et al., 2023).

This literature yields two expectations for realized return. First, return should be

Figure 2: Return during conflict and non-return during peace



Notes: Panel (a): return by origin-conflict intensity (UCDP categories). Panel (b): return rate by log battle deaths. LOESS smoothers; 1989 omitted. Panel (c): global refugee stock and recorded return. Panel (d): return among war-displaced refugees during peace. Sources: GRR; UCDP/PRIO.

more common when the origin country is at peace. Second, large-scale return should be rare while intense conflict continues. To examine whether realized return follows these expectations globally, I use the Global Refugee Return (GRR) Dataset, which records annual refugee stocks and return flows for 293 origin-asylum dyads from 1980 to 2023 and is described in Section 4.2.

Figure 2 shows a striking pattern: most refugees return to war, not peace. Panel (a) shows that most return occurs during war, not after it. Between 1980 and 2023, more than three-quarters of all recorded returns took place while conflict was ongoing in the country of origin, including 17 of the 20 largest episodes. Roughly two-fifths occurred during high-intensity conflict, more than one-third during low-intensity conflict, and only one-fifth during peace. Some of this pattern reflects exposure, since the largest refugee populations disproportionately come from countries experiencing protracted conflict.⁴ But exposure does not resolve the puzzle: it explains why most refugees at

⁴Dyad-years with conflict in the origin constitute 34.1% of observations but contain 72.5% of refugee stock-years at risk and account for 79.0% of recorded returns. Thus, conflict's share of return

risk come from countries at war, not why they return while war continues. Panel (b), which scales returns by the refugee stock at risk, reinforces this point, showing that returns do not decline as battle deaths increase.

Panels (c) and (d) reinforce the puzzle, showing that peace often does not lead to return. Panel (c) plots the total refugee stock against returns over time and shows that returns have generally been rare. Across dyad-years with more than 1,000 refugees, the median return rate is zero and the mean is 2.99%; in 89% of dyad-years, fewer than 5% of refugees return. Panel (d) shows that among refugee populations displaced by war, the average annual return rate is only 3.03% when there is no conflict in the country of origin.⁵ Only 8 of 24 wars that ended and remained at peace for five years saw even half the refugee population return within that period.

3 Theory

Why do refugees often return during ongoing conflict, yet remain in asylum even after peace? To understand global patterns, we need to look beyond refugees' hypothetical preferences over where they would ideally live to the constraints that determine whether those preferences can be acted upon. Refugees who prefer to remain abroad may nevertheless return when conditions in asylum make staying infeasible, while those who want to return may lack the resources needed to move. These constraints are difficult to study through within-context surveys of individual intentions, which have limited leverage on the population-wide shocks that drive major return episodes.⁶

3.1 Constraints on Remaining in Asylum

Two types of shocks can make remaining in asylum infeasible: host-government coercion and armed conflict in the country of asylum. First, host governments may pressure refugees to leave before conditions at home have improved. Despite the prohibition on forced return under the 1951 Refugee Convention,⁷ states may circumvent or ignore *non-refoulement* (Schwartz, 2025; Chimni, 2004; Harrell-Bond, 1989; Long, 2013; Stein and Cuny, 1994). Deportation is the most severe and obvious violation.

exceeds its share of the population at risk by only 6.5 percentage points. Calculations use 5,109 dyad-years with more than 1,000 refugees at risk, excluding 1989, when the *World Refugee Survey* was not published.

⁵This calculation is restricted to origin–asylum dyads in which refugees generally fled war rather than broader non-conflict persecution.

⁶The main cross-national exception, Zakirova and Buzurukov (2021), examines realized return, but similarly emphasizes the political and economic conditions shaping the relative attractiveness of origin and asylum.

⁷*Non-refoulement* is generally recognized as binding all states as customary international law, while states parties to the 1951 Convention or its 1967 Protocol are additionally bound by their treaty obligations.

But governments may also revoke residence permits, restrict access to work and services, withdraw assistance, close camps, or threaten detention and expulsion. These measures can make remaining increasingly difficult while the resulting return is still recorded as “voluntary.”⁸ Consider the treatment of Afghan refugees in Iran in 2005:

“UNHCR [complained] that Iran was pressuring [Afghan refugees] to return by suspending education and medical services and revoking their residence permits. UNHCR also accused Iran of levying a punitive tax on refugees to force them to repatriate. Afghan media reports accused Iranian police of beating refugees and demanding bribes to extend residence permits.”

2006, Iran

Second, armed conflict in the country of asylum can make remaining there more dangerous than returning home. Most refugees remain near their countries of origin, often in neighboring states that share similar structural risk factors for conflict and are vulnerable to the cross-border spread of war (UNHCR, 2025; Fearon and Laitin, 2003; Collier and Hoeffler, 2004; Gleditsch, 2007; Lischer, 2005). Refugees may therefore escape one conflict only to encounter another in asylum. Violence can directly harm refugees or disrupt the humanitarian assistance on which they depend. Under these conditions, refugees may return even while their country of origin remains at war. The 1996 return of Rwandan refugees from the DRC⁹ illustrates this mechanism:

“In October, an outbreak of civil war in Zaire [DRC], which engulfed Rwandan refugee camps there, produced what UNHCR described as the ‘largest and swiftest’ repatriation in memory. About a half-million Rwandan refugees returned home during a four-day period in mid-November. Most returnees repatriated on foot, jamming the main Rwandan highway from the border. The sea of humanity stretched nearly 100 miles during the height of the return.”

1997, Zaire [DRC]

When refugees are forced to leave asylum, onward movement to a third country is possible in principle but often infeasible. Onward migration may seem like a realistic alternative in high-income asylum countries, where refugees have often already traveled considerable distances. But most refugees live in low- and middle-income countries, often near the border they crossed and without the resources or legal permission to travel elsewhere. Many remain in peripheral regions because of community ties or

⁸UNHCR may facilitate repatriation under these conditions, both to reduce the harm refugees would face if expelled without assistance and because it depends on host-government cooperation to maintain access to refugee populations (Barnett, 2001*b,c*; Barnett and Finnemore, 2004; Whitaker, 2003). Its participation does not necessarily establish that refugees would have returned in the absence of government pressure.

⁹The country was officially known as Zaire in 1996 and was renamed the Democratic Republic of the Congo in May 1997. For consistency with current usage, I refer to it as the DRC in the text; quotations and source labels retain the contemporaneous name.

government efforts to contain them there (Camarena, 2024); 79% of UNHCR camps in Africa lie within 50 kilometers of an international border (Fein and Van Den Hoek, 2022). Reaching a third country may therefore require a long, costly, and illegal journey that authorities can block, particularly when host governments are seeking to return refugees home (Whitaker, 2003). When conflict drives refugees from asylum, traveling farther into the host country may also be dangerous. For many refugees unable to remain in asylum, their country of origin is therefore the only destination they can realistically reach.

3.2 Constraints on Returning Home

Returning home can require far more resources than an ordinary international move. Refugees are often returning to places devastated by war, where homes and farmland have been destroyed, local economies have contracted, and there may be few public services. Return therefore requires not only paying for transportation across a border, but resources to rebuild livelihoods and to sustain families while finding new shelter and income sources in a post-conflict economy.

These costs are especially difficult to bear because displacement often limits refugees' ability to accumulate resources. Many spend years in camps or other settings where access to employment is restricted.¹⁰ At the same time, remaining in asylum may offer a degree of material security, whether through humanitarian assistance or through informal work, businesses, and social networks established over years or even decades. Returning means giving up these relatively predictable sources of support for a much riskier environment. Refugees may therefore want to return while lacking the resources needed to rebuild their lives at home.

UNHCR repatriation programs can make such returns feasible. These are often large logistical operations that provide transportation, information, cash, food, shelter materials, legal assistance, and support for restoring housing and livelihoods. The repatriation of Sierra Leonean refugees from Guinea in the early 2000s illustrates the scale of this support:

“About half of the returning refugees received assistance from UNHCR and other agencies in the form of transportation, cooked meals, and medical care during the journey home. . . . Returnees received blankets, cooking utensils, shelter materials, and a two-month food supply. UNHCR appealed for a nine-fold increase in its budget, to \$18 million, to support reintegration programs including schools, health clinics, and livelihood programs.”

2002–2004, Guinea & Sierra Leone

¹⁰Fifty-five percent of refugees live in countries that significantly restrict their right to work in practice (Ginn et al., 2022).

These operations require substantial donor financing, and funding availability can determine how many refugees UNHCR is able to assist and the resources it can provide per person. In 2023, for example, more than 24,000 Burundian refugees had expressed a desire to return, but UNHCR reported a funding shortfall of more than \$13 million for transportation and assistance restarting their lives. At UNHCR’s annual pledging conference, High Commissioner Filippo Grandi said “repatriation is possible, is demanded by refugees, but we can do much less than we would like because there is lack of resources” (Grandi, 2023).

3.3 Formalization

For clarity, I formalize the argument using a standard random utility model of migration choice (Borjas, 1987). Such models allow individual preferences to remain partly unobserved while deriving how changes in common conditions affect the probability of return. This is particularly useful here because major shocks need not induce every refugee to leave. Instead, they shift the relative attractiveness of return for many refugees at once, causing a larger share of the population to cross individual return thresholds.

I extend the standard framework in two ways. First, I incorporate asylum-country push factors, allowing refugees to return even when conditions at home remain unsafe. Second, I incorporate the transition costs of return, allowing refugees who would prefer living at home to remain in asylum because undertaking the move is costly.

Refugee i compares the expected utility of remaining in the asylum country a with that of returning to the origin country o . Utility from remaining in asylum is

$$U_{ai} = v_a(s_a, e_a) - \phi(p_a) + \varepsilon_{ai},$$

where $s_a \in [0, 1]$ indexes security from generalized armed conflict in the asylum country, $e_a \in [0, 1]$ economic conditions, and $v_a : [0, 1]^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ maps these general asylum-country conditions into utility and is strictly increasing in both. Host-government exclusion policies and refugee-targeted violence enters separately through $\phi(p_a)$. The term ε_{ai} captures unobserved individual-specific factors affecting the value of remaining in asylum. The function $\phi(p_a)$ maps the severity of an exclusion policy $p_a \in \mathbb{R}_+$ into the additional cost it imposes on remaining in asylum, with ϕ strictly increasing and $\phi(0) = 0$.¹¹ Exclusion policies may raise the cost of remaining without eliminating choice; deportation is the limiting case in which remaining is no longer feasible.

Utility from returning to the origin country is

¹¹The distinction concerns the source and target of the threat: s_a captures generalized conflict-related insecurity, while $\phi(p_a)$ captures host-government actions directed at refugees, including coercion or violence intended to induce departure.

$$U_{oi} = v_o(s_o, e_o, \rho_o) - \tau_i(p_a, s_a) + \varepsilon_{oi},$$

where $s_o \in [0, 1]$ indexes security in the origin country, $e_o \in [0, 1]$ economic conditions, and $\rho_o \in [0, 1]$ political repression. The function $v_o : [0, 1]^3 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is strictly increasing in s_o and e_o and strictly decreasing in ρ_o , and can implicitly capture an average value across refugees for living in their ancestral home country or locality. The term $\tau_i(p_a, s_a) \geq 0$ captures the transition cost of return, including transportation and the resources needed to re-establish housing and livelihoods. I assume

$$\frac{\partial \tau_i}{\partial p_a} < 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial \tau_i}{\partial s_a} > 0.$$

Stronger exclusionary pressure and worsening security in asylum therefore lower the transition-cost barrier to departure. Refugees planning an orderly return may wait until they can finance transportation, housing, and rebuilding a livelihood, whereas refugees facing coercion or conflict may leave with fewer resources and less preparation.

A refugee has a hypothetical preference for return when $v_o + \varepsilon_{oi} > v_a + \varepsilon_{ai}$. Whether refugee i decides to undertake return, however, depends on whether the total utility of returning exceeds that of remaining in asylum, accounting for exclusion policies and transition costs:

$$U_{oi} > U_{ai} \iff v_o(s_o, e_o, \rho_o) - v_a(s_a, e_a) + \phi(p_a) - \tau_i(p_a, s_a) > \varepsilon_{ai} - \varepsilon_{oi}.$$

A decision to return is not sufficient for realized movement. Let $r_i \in \mathbb{R}_+$ denote the resources available to refugee i , including private resources and external assistance. Realized return requires both

$$U_{oi} > U_{ai} \quad \text{and} \quad r_i \geq \tau_i(p_a, s_a).$$

Refugees who satisfy the first condition but not the second would choose to return but lack the resources needed to move. Additional resources relax this constraint, allowing more refugees to undertake return.

The idiosyncratic utility terms imply that refugees differ in their thresholds for return. Changes in common conditions shift the share of refugees who cross those thresholds. Greater security or economic opportunity at home increases the attractiveness of return, while greater repression reduces it. Exclusion policies and conflict in asylum operate through two channels: they reduce the value of remaining in asylum and lower

the transition-cost barrier to departure. Greater resources affect a different margin, determining whether refugees can finance the transition.

This formulation therefore distinguishes preferences over destinations from realized movement. A refugee may prefer living in the origin country to living in asylum but nevertheless remain abroad because they cannot finance the transition. Conversely, sufficiently severe coercion or insecurity in asylum can both make remaining less attractive and induce refugees to leave with fewer resources and less preparation.

There are therefore two principal routes to realized return. The first is *origin-improvement return*: improving conditions at home raise U_{oi} relative to U_{ai} , but realized return also requires sufficient resources to cover τ_i . The second is *asylum-push return*: exclusion policies or deteriorating security in asylum reduce U_{ai} and lower τ_i , inducing return even without corresponding improvements at home.

3.4 Empirical Implications

The model generates two main hypotheses. First, asylum-side shocks increase return through two channels. Exclusion policies increase $\phi(p_a)$, while conflict in asylum reduces s_a , making remaining in asylum less attractive. Both also lower the resource threshold $\tau_i(p_a, s_a)$ at which refugees are willing to leave. Because neither channel requires improvement at home, asylum-side shocks can increase return even while origin-country conflict continues.

H1 (Asylum-side push). *Refugee return increases following severe exclusion policies and armed conflict in the asylum country, including when conflict continues in the country of origin.*

Second, some refugees who prefer return cannot satisfy the feasibility constraint $r_i \geq \tau_i(p_a, s_a)$. Repatriation assistance increases the resources available for return, raising r_i and allowing more refugees to act on a preference for return.

H2 (Repatriation assistance). *Refugee return is higher when a major UNHCR repatriation programme is operating and increases with the resources available for repatriation assistance.*

Beyond these average associations, the model generates four observable implications. First, if conditions in asylum independently shape return, refugees from the same origin should return at different rates across asylum countries depending on the exclusionary pressure and conflict they face, holding origin-country conditions constant. Second, because asylum-side push does not require an improvement at home, its association with return should persist while conflict continues in the country of origin. Third, if population-level shocks and constraints are important for realized movement, return should be concentrated in particular dyads and years rather than occur as a steady

flow. Exclusion policies, conflict in asylum, and large repatriation operations can all affect many refugees simultaneously. Fourth, if resources constrain return, improvements in origin-country security should translate into greater realized movement when repatriation assistance is available.

These predictions complement rather than replace conventional explanations. When refugees can remain in asylum and have sufficient resources to move, higher s_o and e_o , lower ρ_o , and less attractive conditions in asylum should continue to increase return. The model also does not imply a ranking of the aggregate importance of war endings, exclusion policies, conflict in asylum, and repatriation assistance. Their global importance depends not only on how strongly each condition is associated with return, but also on how many refugees are exposed to it.

4 Data

4.1 Limitations of UNHCR Data

Testing the theory requires cross-national data on realized return, but UNHCR's population statistics, the principal existing source, have important limitations. They are designed primarily to measure voluntary repatriation, omitting forced return, and are vulnerable to systematic undercounting precisely when return is coerced or otherwise pushed.

One problem is that refugees may disappear from UNHCR's population statistics before they are returned. Host governments sometimes withdraw refugee status precisely to facilitate deportation; once individuals are no longer classified as refugees, their subsequent movement may not be recorded as refugee return. Forced returns may also occur where UNHCR has limited access. Governments hostile to refugee protection may restrict its activities, while conflict in the country of asylum may force personnel to evacuate. For example, UNHCR records no returns from South Africa to Mozambique despite contemporaneous reports of large-scale removals:

“With no UNHCR presence in South Africa ... [n]either country recognizes them as refugees ... During 1985, South Africa was returning some 1,500 a month to the danger they had fled.”

1986, South Africa

Refugee population figures can also become politically contested. Host governments may understate return to preserve higher refugee counts and associated aid. In Somalia, for example:

“Somalia refused to accept any reduced estimate ... UNHCR reluctantly continued to provide assistance for the supposed 840,000 refugees ... [before] publicly

refut[ing] that figure, saying that the actual number is less than half that.”

1989, Somalia

These measurement problems are not random. Returns are especially likely to go unrecorded when refugees lose formal status, move outside assisted channels, or return from settings where humanitarian access is limited. Analyses based only on UNHCR data may therefore understate forced return precisely in the cases central to this paper.

4.2 The Global Refugee Return Dataset

To study realized return, I created the Global Refugee Return (GRR) Dataset. GRR includes origin populations with at least 25,000 refugees in exile in any year and uses a broad definition of refugees that includes formally recognized refugees, asylum seekers, and unregistered refugees. For each origin population, I include the principal asylum countries that collectively host at least 75% of that population.¹²

To address the measurement problems described above, GRR draws primarily on contemporaneous country reports that combine locally collected information with official and nonofficial sources. These reports often capture refugee dynamics missing from administrative data, including unregistered populations, spontaneous and forced returns, and disputes over official figures. Their coverage is also less dependent on the presence of any single international organization and, because the reporting organizations did not administer refugee assistance, less directly exposed to the political pressures surrounding aid-linked population estimates.

The principal source is the *World Refugee Survey* (WRS), published annually by the U.S. Committee for Refugees and Immigrants from 1980 through 2008. USCRI describes its reporting process as follows:

“[A] rigorous method including, when possible, site visits to the countries on which we report. In most countries, we have Research Partners—local human rights NGOs that interview officials, refugees, and representatives of local civil society and international agencies based on our standard questionnaire . . . We consult with and seek the input of representatives of each government . . . We receive extensive input from the field offices of UNHCR and UNRWA. Finally, we crosscheck all of this with secondary sources in the media, on the internet, and in major governmental and nongovernmental human rights reports.”

USCRI, 2008

The *core* dataset covers Global South asylum countries from 1980 through 2008, where

¹²The 75% threshold is calculated using UNHCR data, supplemented with data on Palestinian refugees under UNRWA and Mozambican refugees in South Africa, whom the UNHCR data list under an unknown country of asylum.

WRS reporting is most consistent.¹³ The *extended* series adds high-income asylum countries and continues through 2023 using the U.S. Department of State’s annual country reports on human rights practices. These reports contain country-level reporting on refugees and migrants, including forced return, exclusion policies, and unregistered populations (U.S. Department of State, 2024). Because the *State* reports do not always provide refugee stock or voluntary return estimates, the extended series uses UNHCR figures as a baseline and supplements them with additional evidence on forced returns and unregistered populations. The extended series therefore provides broader geographic and temporal coverage, while the core series offers more consistent measurement.

Constructing GRR required digitizing WRS reports, many available only as scans or physical volumes. I hand-coded the 25 largest origin populations, covering 83 dyads, and worked with 36 trained research assistants to code the remainder using a common protocol. I then reviewed and adjudicated every observation, returning to the original reports, adjacent years, and additional desk research when GRR and UNHCR figures differed substantially. To my knowledge, this is the first project to digitize and systematically code the full WRS corpus, producing 7,526 dyad-year observations.

A comparison with UNHCR data, reported in the Appendix, lends support to the measurement concerns raised above. Across the GRR core sample, UNHCR records 19.1 million returns compared with 19.5 million voluntary returns in GRR, indicating close agreement on voluntary repatriation. However, UNHCR data appears to underreport coerced returns. GRR records an additional 3.6 million forced returns that UNHCR does not capture, meaning that UNHCR records only 83% of total realized return. Nearly one-third of forced-return episodes in GRR are entirely absent from UNHCR data, and almost half of forced-return volume occurs in episodes that are either absent or only minimally recorded.

5 Empirical Analysis

The empirical analysis examines within-dyad associations using PPML and event studies, then examines observable implications of the theory, and then briefly discusses aggregate patterns.

5.1 Within-Dyad PPML Estimates

I estimate Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood (PPML) models with dyad and year fixed effects. The unit of analysis is the directed origin–asylum dyad-year, and the dependent variable is the number of refugees who return during the year. Table 1 sum-

¹³It contains 105 dyads across 58 origin populations and 61 asylum countries. The WRS was not published in 1990, so GRR has no observations for 1989.

Table 1: Explanatory variables

Variable	Measure	Source	Period
Asylum-country push			
Exclusion Policy	Host-government pressure to induce return: 0 = none, 1 = moderate, 2 = severe. Severe policies are implemented measures intended to affect at least 10% of the refugee stock; coding is based on policy, not subsequent return.	WRS; U.S. State Department	1980–2023
Conflict in COA	Armed conflict in asylum: none, low (25–999 battle deaths), or high ($\geq 1,000$); based on conflict location.	UCDP	1980–2023
UNHCR repatriation assistance			
Repatriation Assistance	Logged UNHCR repatriation funding per refugee in the origin country’s global refugee population; measured at the origin-year level.	UNHCR ExCom; Yearbooks	1980–1999; 2011–2020
Existing explanations			
Conflict in COO	Armed conflict in origin: none, low (25–999 battle deaths), or high ($\geq 1,000$); matched to the conflict producing displacement.	UCDP; author matching	1980–2023
War Ending	First three peaceful years after the displacement-producing war ends, provided conflict does not resume.	Fearon (2017); author extension	1980–2023
Civil Liberties Restrictions (COO)	Freedom House civil liberties index: 1 = greatest protection, 7 = least protection.	Freedom House	1980–2023
GDP (COO)	Logged GDP per capita in the country of origin.	World Bank WDI	1980–2023
GDP (COA)	Logged GDP per capita in the country of asylum.	World Bank WDI	1980–2023
Refugee Rights	De jure refugee and asylum policy; higher values indicate more liberal policies.	DWRAP (Blair, Grossman and Weinstein, 2022)	1980–2022
Conflict Duration	Logged age of the displacement-producing conflict spell, used as a proxy for time in asylum; one quiet year is tolerated and the counter resets after two.	Derived from UCDP	1980–2023

marizes the explanatory variables, their measurement, sources, and temporal coverage.

I employ a PPML estimator because it accommodates a non-negative, highly skewed outcome with many zeros without transforming the outcome or dropping zero-return observations. In the model, dyad fixed effects absorb time-invariant differences across refugee populations and origin–asylum relationships, so the estimates are identified from changes within the same dyad over time. Year fixed effects absorb shocks common to all dyads. Because the analysis is observational, I interpret the estimates as conditional associations rather than causal effects.

I include the log refugee population at risk as an offset, so coefficients describe proportional differences in the return rate rather than differences driven by population size. The population at risk is the previous year’s refugee stock.¹⁴ I restrict the analysis to dyad-years with more than 1,000 refugees at risk. The baseline model is

¹⁴In 21 dyad-years, a large inflow arrives and returns within the same year, causing return to exceed the lagged stock; for these observations, I use the estimated within-year peak population.

$$E[Y_{it} \mid \mathbf{X}_{it}] = \exp(\beta' \mathbf{X}_{it} + \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \ln S_{it-1}), \quad (1)$$

where Y_{it} is the number of returnees in dyad i and year t , $\mathbf{X}_{it}$ is the vector of time-varying covariates, α_i and γ_t are dyad and year fixed effects, and $\ln S_{it-1}$ is the offset. Standard errors are clustered by dyad.

Table 2 presents the main estimates, and panel (a) of Figure 3 plots the corresponding return-rate ratios. Model 1 is the primary specification. Model 2 adds UNHCR repatriation assistance and therefore uses the smaller subset of origin-years for which funding data are available. The mean return rate in the Model 1 sample is 6.6%.¹⁵

H1 predicts that asylum-side push increases return even when conditions at home have not improved. The strongest evidence is for exclusion policies. Relative to years without an exclusion policy, a severe policy is associated with 2.97 times the return rate (coefficient 1.09, SE = 0.19), the largest association in panel (a) of Figure 3. A moderate policy is associated with a 62% higher return rate (coefficient 0.48, SE = 0.22; return-rate ratio = 1.62).

Conflict in the country of asylum is also associated with higher return. Low-intensity conflict is associated with 2.24 times the return rate (coefficient 0.81, SE = 0.21), while high-intensity conflict is associated with 1.80 times the rate (coefficient 0.59, SE = 0.31). The low-intensity estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero, whereas the high-intensity estimate is less precise, and a Wald test does not reject equality of the two coefficients. The results therefore support an association between conflict in asylum and return, but not a clear difference by conflict intensity. This finding is less robust than that for exclusion policies, and leave-one-region-out checks in the Appendix suggest that the association is concentrated in Sub-Saharan Africa.

H2 predicts that refugees who want to return may nevertheless remain abroad if they lack the resources to move, so return should increase with the resources available for repatriation. Consistent with this expectation, high funding is associated with 1.82 times the return rate relative to none (coefficient 0.60, SE = 0.30), and moving from low to high UNHCR repatriation funding is associated with approximately 2.3 times the return rate. Appendix analyses show similar patterns using two alternative measures of repatriation assistance.

¹⁵This is higher than in the broader estimation frame because fixed-effects PPML excludes dyads that never record return. The estimation sample contains 2,327 dyad-years across 110 dyads, from an estimation frame of 5,131 dyad-years in 285 dyads. Of the 175 excluded dyads, 148 record no return in any year, 25 are lost to covariate missingness, and 2 are single-year dyads absorbed by the fixed effects. The fitted sample contains 75.6% of all return recorded in GRR and 58.7% of refugee stock-years in the estimation frame. The appendix reports a cross-national model that retains dyads without within-dyad variation in return.

Table 2: Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood estimates of refugee return

Term	(1) Main	(2) With assistance
Asylum-side push		
Exclusion policy: severe	1.09*** (0.19)	1.31*** (0.35)
Exclusion policy: moderate	0.48* (0.22)	0.16 (0.27)
Conflict in COA: high	0.59 [†] (0.31)	0.88* (0.44)
Conflict in COA: low	0.81*** (0.21)	0.95** (0.35)
Repatriation assistance		
Repatriation funding: high	—	0.60* (0.30)
Repatriation funding: low	—	-0.23 (0.34)
Existing explanations		
War Ending	1.00*** (0.22)	0.97** (0.36)
Conflict in COO: high	0.11 (0.28)	0.35 (0.34)
Conflict in COO: low	0.30 (0.22)	0.35 (0.25)
GDP (COO)	0.39 (0.28)	0.67 (0.47)
GDP (COA)	-1.09 [†] (0.59)	-1.23 (0.82)
Civil Liberties Restrictions (COO)	-0.51** (0.17)	-0.09 (0.24)
Refugee Rights	-0.02 (0.17)	-0.10 (0.22)
Conflict Duration	-0.03 (0.08)	-0.11 (0.13)
Specification and fit		
Dyad and year fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Sample	Extended GRR	Funding coded
Years	1980–2022	1980–1999, 2011–2020
Dyad-years	2,327	1,378
Dyads	110	100
Pseudo R ²	0.799	0.783

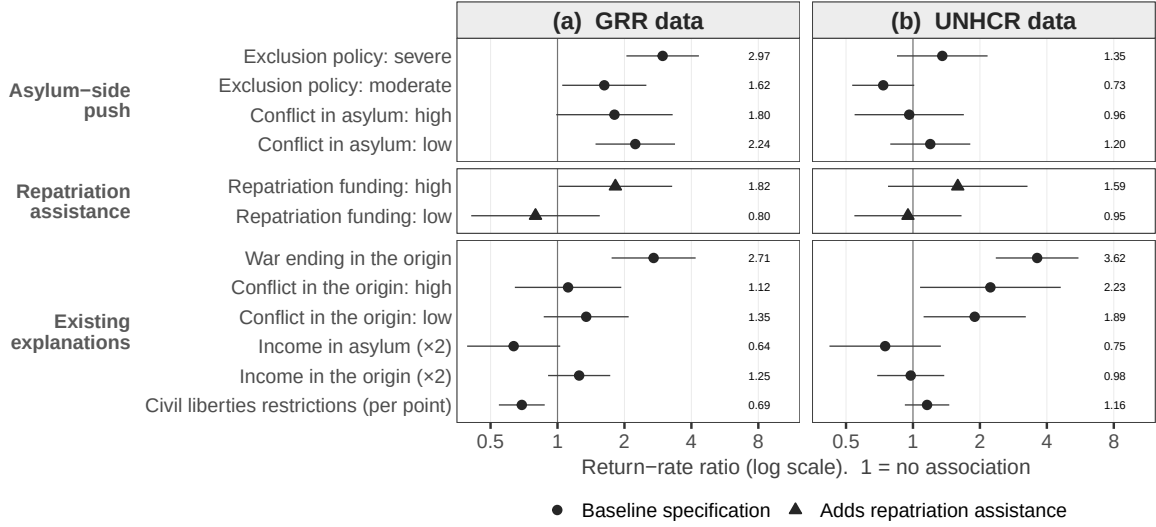
Notes: PPML with the log refugee stock at risk as an offset and standard errors clustered by dyad. Column 2 includes repatriation assistance and is estimated on a smaller sample.

Among existing explanations, the clearest predictor is the end of war. The post-war window is associated with 2.71 times the return rate (coefficient 1.00, SE = 0.22). By contrast, neither low- nor high-intensity conflict in the origin is significantly associated with return relative to peace. Greater civil-liberties restrictions in the origin are associated with less return, while higher asylum-country income is also negatively associated with return, though imprecisely estimated. Origin-country income, refugee rights in asylum, and conflict duration are not distinguishable from zero.

5.2 Event-Study Evidence

I next examine the timing of these relationships using stacked event studies. This provides a complementary use of the within-dyad variation underlying Table 2 and, importantly, tests whether return was already changing before each condition occurred. Because these conditions are not absorbing, I stack a separate comparison around each onset. Treated dyads are observed from three years before to three years after

Figure 3: What predicts refugee return, and when peace translates into return



Notes: PPML; dyad and year FE; log refugee-stock offset; dyad-clustered SEs; 95% CIs. Panel (a): GRR. Circles: Model 1 of Table 2, N=2,327 dyad-years. Triangles: Model 2 of Table 2, N=1,378. Panel (b): UNHCR (see model in appendix). N=2,126. Triangles: N=1,207.

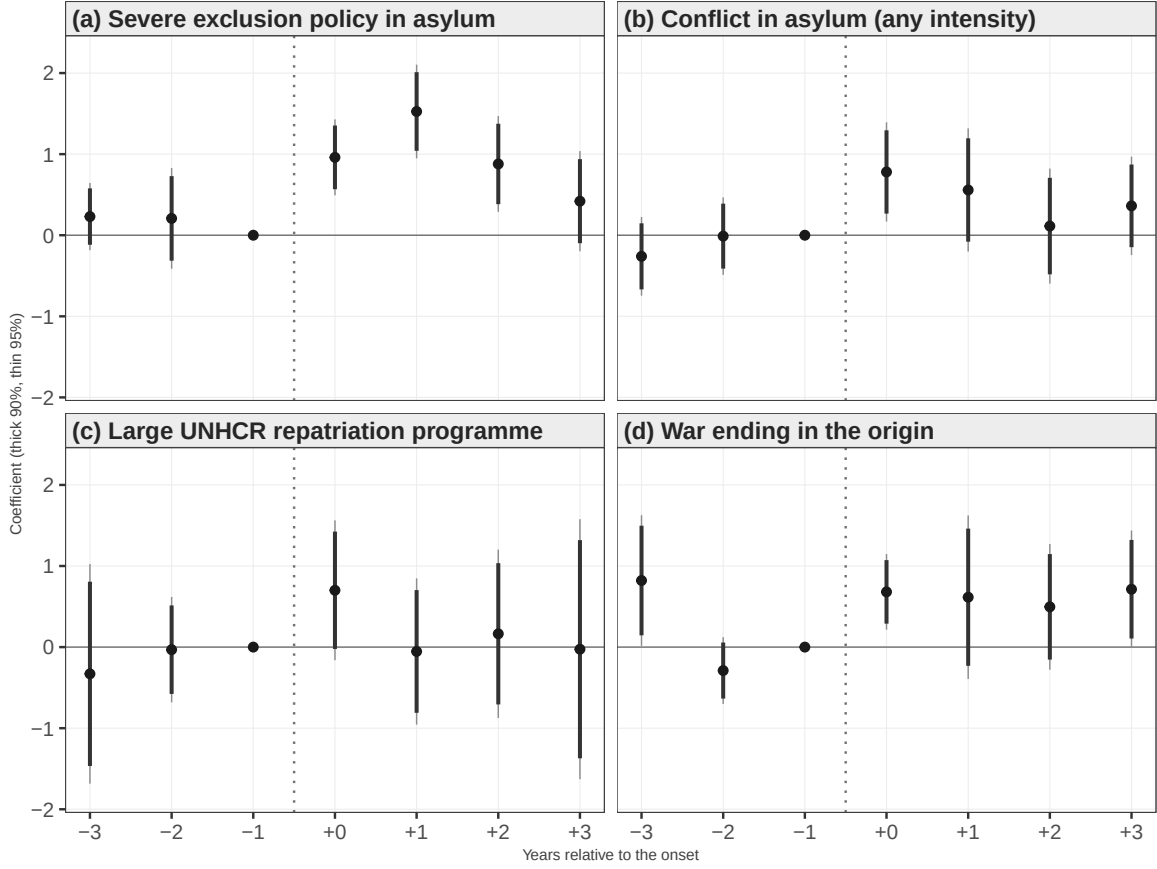
onset and compared with dyads that remain unexposed to the corresponding condition throughout the window; the year before onset is the reference period.¹⁶

Figure 4 broadly reproduces the main PPML findings while providing little evidence that the asylum-side relationships reflect return already underway. Following the onset of a severe exclusion policy, return rises to approximately 2.6 times its pre-onset level in the onset year and 4.6 times the following year. Conflict in the asylum country is likewise followed by approximately 2.2 times as much return in the onset year. In both cases, the pre-onset coefficients are jointly indistinguishable from zero ($p = 0.55$ and $p = 0.45$, respectively).

The pattern for repatriation assistance is similar but less precisely estimated, reflecting the smaller number of observed programme onsets due to data limitations. Return approximately doubles when a major UNHCR repatriation programme begins, while there is no evidence that return was already changing beforehand ($p = 0.85$ for the joint test of the leads). This is reassuring given the concern that UNHCR may initiate repatriation programmes once return is already under way, although it cannot rule out broader selection into where and when assistance is provided. I return to this concern in Section 6. Programme onset and realized return are coded from separate archival sources, so the timing relationship does not arise mechanically from the construction of

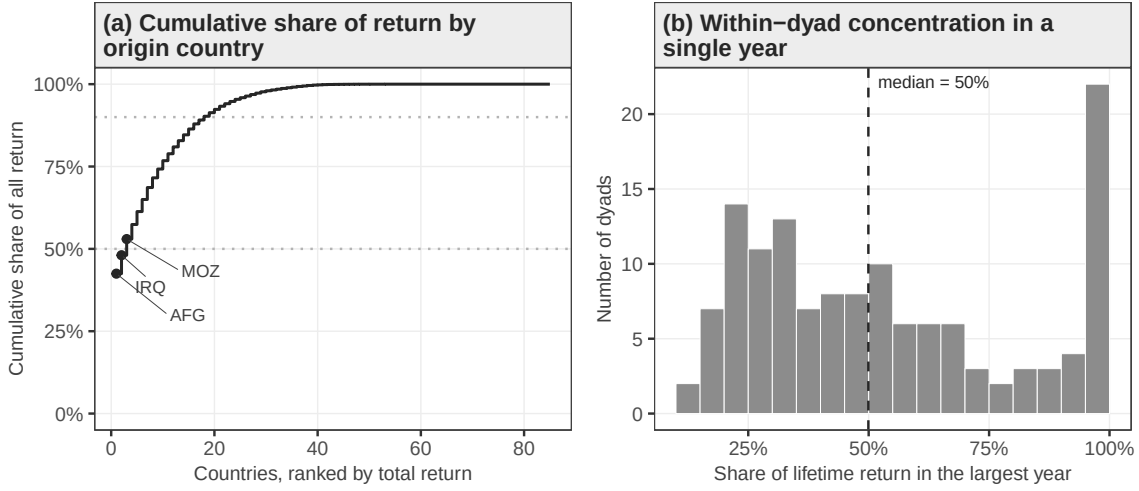
¹⁶A cohort enters only if the condition is observed and absent throughout the three preceding years. Conditions may persist or lapse after onset. The Appendix reports the specification and additional details.

Figure 4: Return around the onset of asylum shocks, repatriation assistance, and war endings



Notes: Stacked PPML; ± 3 yrs; cohort $\times$ dyad and cohort $\times$ year FE; log stock-at-risk offset; dyad-clustered SEs; $t-1$ omitted. Cohorts require the condition absent 3 prior yrs; controls unexposed in-window. Bars: 90%/95%. Cohorts and treated dyads, with the p -value from a joint test that all pre-onset coefficients are zero: (a) 23 cohorts, 17 treated dyads, $p = 0.55$; (b) 45 and 36, $p = 0.45$; (c) 29 and 24, $p = 0.85$; (d) 49 and 44, $p = 0.01$.

Figure 5: Concentration of recorded refugee return



Notes: Panel (a): full GRR sample, 7,498 dyad-years, 292 dyads, 85 origins; dotted lines: 50th/90th percentiles of cumulative return. Panel (b): 135 dyads observed for at least 5 yrs with recorded return.

the return measure. For comparison, war endings are likewise followed by higher return, but exhibit a statistically significant pre-trend ($p = 0.011$). Return was therefore already increasing before the war formally ended.

5.3 Observable Implications

The theory generates several observable implications beyond the average associations examined above. First, if population-level shocks are important for realized movement, return should be concentrated in particular places and years rather than occur as a steady annual flow. Figure 5 shows precisely this pattern. The top 5% of dyad-years account for 93.8% of return, and the top 1% for 63.5%. Among dyads that record any return, 49.6% have at least half their lifetime return in one year, while 19.3% experience at least 90% in one year. The timing of these episodes also suggests that war endings alone do not account for this concentration: asylum-side shocks coincide with 47.4% of recorded return, compared with 15.4% during war-ending windows.

Second, if conditions in asylum independently shape realized return, refugees from the same origin should return at different rates across asylum countries. I test this using origin-by-year fixed effects, which absorb all origin-specific conditions in a given year and identify asylum-side associations from differences across host countries. The Appendix shows that the main patterns persist: refugees are more likely to return from asylum countries experiencing exclusionary policies or conflict than are refugees from the same origin elsewhere. Complementary asylum-by-year fixed effects likewise show

that, within the same host country and year, groups targeted by exclusionary policies return at higher rates than untargeted groups.

Third, asylum-side push should increase return even when conditions at home remain unsafe. Interaction models reported in the Appendix show that the associations between severe exclusion policies, asylum-country conflict, and return are similar whether conflict continues in the country of origin or has ended.

Fourth, if resources constrain return, improvements in origin-country security should translate into greater realized movement when repatriation assistance is available. The descriptive pattern is consistent with this implication. In dyad-years in the post-war period without a UNHCR repatriation programme, the return rate is 4.4% compared to 31.3% when a UNHCR program is operating. The within-dyad interaction points in the same direction: a war ending is associated with 1.8 times the return rate without substantial repatriation funding, compared with 3.4 times the rate when substantial funding is present. The interaction is imprecisely estimated (0.66, SE = 0.56), so I interpret this evidence as consistent with, rather than a decisive test of, the resource mechanism.

Beyond these observable implications, I assess the aggregate importance of the principal predictors. I use Model 2 to compare fitted return under the observed data with fitted return when each factor is set to its reference value, holding other covariates fixed. These simulations are illustrative rather than causal and ask how much lower fitted return would be in the absence of each condition. Fitted aggregate return is 22.1% lower without severe exclusion policies, 15.1% lower without large repatriation assistance, and 12.1% lower without high-intensity conflict in asylum, compared with 9.9% lower without the post-war window.

6 Alternative Explanations and Robustness

I address three broad concerns about the results. The Appendix reports the principal robustness analyses.

A first set of robustness checks considers alternative explanations for the main results. One possibility is that the relationship between conflict and return reflects anticipatory return before wars end rather than asylum-country push factors. There is some evidence of this: return is modestly elevated before war endings, as shown in the event-study evidence in Section 5.2. However, anticipation cannot account for the main result. Only 11 of 129 severe-policy dyad-years fall within three years before a war ending, and excluding all dyad-years within three years on either side of an ending leaves the severe-policy estimate essentially unchanged. Adding the war-ending year directly to the model produces the same result.

Another possibility is that higher return during conflict reflects failed asylum claims: people flee, are rejected, and return, with this movement counted as repatriation. This is unlikely to explain the results. People turned away at the border are not included, and the return data and archival reports indicate that large return episodes generally involve recognized refugees or people who had been living in the asylum country without formal status. Moreover, large asylum-seeker populations are concentrated in the Global North, as many countries in the Global South automatically recognize people fleeing particular conflicts as *prima facie* refugees (United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, N.d.). Severe policies also tend to target large, long-established refugee populations, a pattern supported by Appendix diagnostics linking lagged refugee population size to policy onset.

A second concern is selection into repatriation assistance. UNHCR may direct programmes and resources toward cases where it anticipates substantial return or where conditions at home have already improved. The event study provides some reassurance, since return does not increase before programme onset, but it cannot rule out this broader form of selection. Additional analyses in the Appendix provide two further pieces of evidence. First, among cases receiving funding, return increases with the amount of funding available per refugee (coefficient 0.82, SE = 0.21), rather than simply with the presence of a funded programme. Second, assistance often arrives after the immediate post-war period. Among programmes that follow a war ending, the median programme begins one year later, 24% begin at least two years later, and 10% begin five or more years later. In the fourteen post-war episodes where assistance begins at least three years after the war ends, return averages 0.8% in the two years before assistance and 9.9% over the three years beginning with its arrival. The timing of tripartite repatriation agreements shows a similar pattern. These delayed cases help separate the arrival of repatriation support from the immediate effect of improved security at home.

The third set of checks concern the validity of the exclusion policy measure. Because coding archival reports requires judgment, I make each classification auditable by providing the supporting text and coding rules in the GRR data file. Policies are coded based on their intent and implementation, not on whether forced return actually occurs. Consistent with this, 36% of moderate-policy and 8% of severe-policy dyad-years record no return. Severe policy remains statistically significant when the outcome is restricted to returns coded as voluntary. As a consistency check, exclusion policies are less common where DWRAP records stronger protections against refoulement. Finally, I apply the same coding rules to Amnesty International reports to assess whether the classifications can be reproduced using an independent source corpus.¹⁷

I examine the robustness of the findings across alternative measures of return, conflict, and war endings; different estimators and clustering strategies; lagged covariates and

¹⁷The data collection and analysis is underway.

additional fixed effects; alternative samples, including core GRR; and the exclusion of refugee-warrior cases, particular regions, and the largest origins, asylum countries, dyads, and return episodes. The severe-policy association is the most robust, remaining positive and significant across nearly all of these checks. The asylum-country conflict and repatriation funding results also generally persist. Among the existing explanations, restrictions on civil liberties at home are relatively robust, while the post-war association is more sensitive to the outcome, sample, and definition of a war ending; the remaining predictors show less consistent relationships with return.

The Appendix also considers a broader set of existing explanations that cannot all be incorporated directly into the main within-dyad specification. I examine changes in the political position of refugees' ethnic groups in both origin and asylum countries. Return is higher when refugee groups gain political standing in the origin, while I find little evidence that changes in the political position of co-ethnics in asylum predict return. Cross-dyad comparisons likewise provide little evidence that transnational ethnic kin or Refugee Convention membership are associated with return. Higher income in both origin and asylum countries is associated with lower return, while return is lower between countries sharing a widely spoken language and higher where their religious composition is more similar. Finally, I examine whether conventional quality-of-life factors matter more once security at home improves. The clearest pattern is for asylum-country income: war endings are associated with substantially more return from poorer asylum countries but essentially no increase from wealthier ones; corresponding differences by origin-country income and civil liberties are smaller and less precisely estimated. These analyses suggest that economic, political, and social conditions matter in some contexts, but do not provide an alternative explanation for the principal asylum-side associations.

I also assess whether the findings depend on using GRR rather than UNHCR's official return data. Panel (b) of Figure 3 re-estimates the same specifications using UNHCR return counts and shows markedly different patterns. The associations with severe exclusion policies and conflict in asylum largely disappear, while a moderate exclusion policy is associated with less recorded return. At the same time, UNHCR-recorded return is higher during conflict in the country of origin and, in the smaller assistance sample, where civil-liberties restrictions are greater. Nor is there a clear association between repatriation funding and return. These patterns are difficult to reconcile either with the asylum-side mechanisms documented above or with a simple account in which refugees return as conditions at home improve. They are instead consistent with the measurement evidence showing that UNHCR data omit many coerced and asylum-driven returns captured by GRR, although the comparison cannot by itself establish that measurement differences account for every discrepancy.

7 Case Studies

To illustrate the mechanisms underlying the cross-national results, I examine two historical cases. The first compares Rwandan refugees across Burundi, the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC), and Tanzania in 1996. Because refugees from the same origin faced broadly similar conditions at home, differences in the timing of return across asylum countries help illustrate how coercion and conflict in asylum can produce return even without an improvement in origin-country conditions. The second examines Eritrean refugees in Sudan after the end of Ethiopia's civil war. In this case, peace did not immediately produce large-scale return, but return increased after UNHCR repatriation assistance became available.

7.1 Asylum-Side Push: Rwandan Refugees in Burundi, the DRC, and Tanzania, 1996

After the 1994 genocide and the subsequent victory of the Tutsi-led Rwandan Patriotic Front, hundreds of thousands of Hutu fled to neighboring countries, including members of the former government and armed forces implicated in the genocide. Although the new Rwandan government encouraged return and UNHCR intensified repatriation efforts in 1995, most refugees remained in Burundi, the DRC, and Tanzania. Many feared violence or arrest in Rwanda, while former-regime leaders intimidated refugees and sometimes prevented them from leaving the camps. Efforts to promote voluntary repatriation therefore initially produced relatively little return.

Mass return instead followed distinct shocks in each country of asylum. In Burundi, the government increasingly pressured Rwandan refugees to leave during 1996. Officials told refugees they were no longer welcome, soldiers and local militias attacked and burned camps, and authorities forcibly transported refugees across the border. In July, soldiers expelled 15,000 refugees and temporarily blocked UNHCR access to two camps. By year's end, "about 98 percent of Rwandan refugees had left Burundi, due to fear for their safety and coercive policies by Burundian authorities" (1997, Burundi).

In the DRC, repatriation efforts likewise produced little movement until civil war reached the refugee camps in October 1996. Rebel attacks dispersed some former-regime leaders who had obstructed departure, while the fighting itself forced refugees from the camps. More than half a million returned within four days in what UNHCR described as the "largest and swiftest repatriation in memory" (1997, Zaire). Some returned willingly once freed from camp leaders' control, while others returned to escape the fighting or because they had no other option. At least 200,000 instead moved deeper into the DRC. Their attempt to remain outside Rwanda is important for interpreting the return that did occur: displacement from the camps did not uniformly reflect a new preference for return.

Return from Tanzania followed yet another asylum-side shock. Only 2% of Rwandan refugees returned during the first eleven months of 1996. On December 5, following the return from the DRC, the government proclaimed that “all Rwandese refugees can now return to their country in safety” and imposed a year-end deadline for departure (1997, Tanzania). Hundreds of thousands initially moved deeper into Tanzania, away from Rwanda, but security forces blocked their movement, closed the camps, and directed them toward the border. Return subsequently reached as many as 15,000 people per hour, while approximately 50,000 avoided repatriation by dispersing elsewhere in Tanzania or presenting themselves as Burundian.

The staggered timing across these three countries is difficult to explain through changes in Rwanda alone. Refugees faced the same Rwandan government and broadly similar origin-country conditions, yet mass return followed coercion in Burundi, conflict reaching the camps in the DRC, and an expulsion order in Tanzania. Refugees’ efforts to move farther into the DRC and Tanzania show that many did not want to return. The episode therefore illustrates the central implication of H1. Realized return can rise sharply when remaining in asylum becomes infeasible, even without a corresponding improvement in refugees’ country of origin.

7.2 Post-War Return and Repatriation Assistance: Eritrean Refugees in Sudan, 1991–2005

The experience of Eritrean refugees in Sudan illustrates a different constraint on realized return. Hundreds of thousands of Tigrayans and Eritreans had fled Ethiopia’s civil war into Sudan beginning in the 1960s. In May 1991, the Mengistu regime fell and the EPLF took control of Eritrea, bringing the conflict to an end. If improved security at home were sufficient to generate return, this change should have produced rapid large-scale repatriation. Instead, only about 10,000 refugees returned in the year of independence.

One obstacle was the absence of a large repatriation operation. A dispute between the Eritrean government and UNHCR over the scale and financing of reconstruction assistance prevented the immediate launch of a return program. Eritrea sought more rehabilitation assistance than donors were willing to provide. A UNHCR repatriation program eventually began in 1994 and approximately 81,000 refugees returned over the following two years, but roughly 320,000 remained in Sudan. Return subsequently stalled amid “financial disputes over the scope of the repatriation program, and deteriorating relations between the governments of Sudan and Eritrea” (WRS, Sudan, 1997), alongside insecurity near the border.

A second repatriation effort around 2000 provided transportation, reintegration grants, and housing assistance. Approximately 130,000 refugees returned over the following five years. The timing is consistent with the mechanism in H2: after the war had

already ended, return increased when institutional and financial support reduced the costs of moving and rebuilding a life in Eritrea.

Many refugees continued to remain in Sudan even once assistance became available. By this point, some had lived there for decades and had established livelihoods and social ties. By the early 1990s, half lived in camps with access to food aid, health and education programs, and technical training, often near relatives or co-ethnics and with access to agricultural land, while the remainder lived in urban areas. When encouraged to return in 2001, “many would-be returnees chose to remain longer in Sudan to harvest their crops” (WRS, Sudan, 2002). A survey reported that roughly 85 percent of refugee households considered assistance levels in Eritrea an important determinant of whether they would return.

Even the formal termination of refugee status did not produce universal repatriation. In 2002, UNHCR invoked the cessation clause, requiring Eritreans to “repatriate, file individualized asylum claims to remain in Sudan as refugees, or take steps to become permanent legal residents of Sudan” (WRS, Sudan, 2003). Only 25,000 repatriated in 2002 and 9,500 in 2003, while many remained in Sudan.

The contrast with the Rwandan case highlights the two constraints emphasized in the theory. Rwandan refugees returned in large numbers when coercion or conflict undermined their ability to remain in asylum, despite limited evidence that conditions at home had become more attractive at precisely those moments. Eritrean refugees, by contrast, often remained abroad after the war had ended, and return increased as organized repatriation assistance became available. Yet when refugees were given the option to remain in Sudan by seeking permanent legal residence, rather than being compelled to leave, many chose to stay. Together, the cases show why realized return cannot be inferred from origin-country security alone. Whether refugees actually move also depends on whether remaining in asylum is feasible and whether refugees have the resources needed to undertake return.

8 Conclusion

This paper revisits a foundational premise of the international refugee regime: that refugees receive protection while conditions at home remain unsafe and return once those conditions improve. Using the Global Refugee Return dataset, which covers 293 origin–asylum dyads from 1980 to 2023, I show that realized return often follows a different pattern. Most recorded returns occur while conflict is still ongoing in the country of origin, while many refugees remain abroad long after war has ended.

I argue that realized return depends not only on refugees’ individual or household-level preferences over origin and asylum, but also on population-level conditions that determine whether remaining abroad and undertaking return are feasible. Host-government

coercion and conflict in asylum can make staying infeasible, while repatriation assistance can make return possible for refugees who otherwise lack the resources to move.

The empirical results support both parts of the argument. Within the same refugee populations over time, severe exclusion policies and conflict in asylum are associated with substantially higher return, including while conflict continues at home, while greater UNHCR repatriation assistance is also associated with more return. Stacked event studies show return rising after the onset of each, with little evidence that these patterns were already underway beforehand. The broader observable implications point in the same direction: return is highly concentrated in particular dyads and years, refugees from the same origin return at different rates across asylum countries, and post-war return is substantially higher when repatriation assistance is available.

These findings help reconcile existing research on return intentions with global patterns of realized movement. Individual preferences remain important, but population-level constraints help determine whether those preferences translate into movement: shocks in asylum can induce return without improvements at home, while limited resources can delay return even after peace.

This has important implications for how observed repatriation is interpreted within the refugee regime. Voluntary return after peace can provide a durable solution when refugees want to return and can do so safely, but return itself is not necessarily evidence that these conditions have been met. Some of the largest movements instead occur under coercive pressure and while conflict continues at home, while other returns depend heavily on international assistance to finance transportation and reintegration, assistance that may be threatened by recent aid cuts. The conditions under which return occurs may therefore shape both returnees' welfare and reintegration (Fransen, Ruiz and Vargas-Silva, 2017) and the consequences of mass return for origin communities and post-conflict politics (Schwartz, 2019; Blair, Van Dijke and Wright, 2026).

This distinction also matters for how repatriation is understood within the refugee regime. Voluntary return after peace can provide a durable solution when refugees want to return and can do so safely, but observed return is not necessarily evidence that these conditions have been met. Some of the largest return movements instead occur under coercive pressure and while conflict continues at home, while other returns depend heavily on international assistance to finance transportation and reintegration, which may be under threat with recent aid cuts. The conditions under which return occurs may therefore shape both returnees' welfare and reintegration (Fransen, Ruiz and Vargas-Silva, 2017) and the consequences of mass return for origin communities and post-conflict politics (Schwartz, 2019; Blair, Van Dijke and Wright, 2026).

The analysis also underscores the difficulty of measuring refugee return. Existing UNHCR statistics omit many forced and spontaneous returns, including the coercive movements central to the argument here. GRR reconstructs refugee stocks and re-

alized return and adds new data on exclusion policies, but it still relies on expert reporting and remains an imperfect measure of movements that are often difficult to observe precisely. Other poorly measured displacement dynamics remain beyond its scope and important for future research, including efforts to prevent access to asylum through maritime pushbacks and border closures (FitzGerald, 2019; Goodwin-Gill, 2011; Schwartz, 2025), as well as temporary and repeated movement between origin and asylum (Masterson and Vidarte, 2026). These dynamics remain difficult to study cross-nationally because existing data rarely track them systematically.

Several questions follow. First, when and why do governments impose exclusion policies? Analysis in the appendix suggests that severe coercion is concentrated in large, unresolved displacement crises. Population size is its most consistent correlate, while crisis duration, origin-country violence, and host characteristics are much less robust predictors. More detailed case analysis could examine the domestic pressures behind these decisions, the role of international aid and diplomacy, and whether host governments face meaningful costs for violating the refugee regime’s core protection principle. Future research should also examine the role of origin governments, which may encourage return to signal normalization, but resist it when they lack the capacity to absorb returnees or regard particular groups as political or security threats.

More broadly, the paper brings the refugee regime into debates about the performance of international regimes. *Non-refoulement* is its core legal principle, yet the analysis reveals both continued protection and systematic violations at scale. UNHCR may even facilitate return under coercive conditions when refusing to participate would leave refugees without assistance or jeopardize its access. This variation raises a question familiar from research on other international institutions but rarely examined systematically in the refugee regime: why are core rules upheld in some cases but violated in others, and when do international organizations constrain rather than accommodate those violations?

Taken together, the findings show that repatriation does not automatically follow the restoration of peace. Displacement may end because protection in asylum erodes, because international assistance makes return possible, or it may persist long after the conflict that produced it has ended. Explaining when displacement ends therefore requires understanding the political processes that determine whether states continue to provide asylum or push refugees to leave, when donors finance repatriation, and when UNHCR facilitates return, as well as where refugees displaced by war, often for decades, want to live.

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